FOR COUNSELOR USE · TEENS

My Inner World: Facilitator Guide

A low-pressure, visual way for teens to share who they are. A flexible conversation, not a test or assessment.

Suggested flow (20 to 30 minutes of a 50-minute session)

1. Offer a choice 2 min	"Want to make a tree map together? It's okay to say no."
2. Start anywhere 5 min	"Which part feels easiest to start with?"
3. Follow their meaning 10 to 15 min	"What does that part mean to you?" · "Want to tell me a little more?"
4. Notice experience 3 min	"Talking about this, what do you notice in your body or mind?"
5. Close with agency 3 min	"Is there a part of the tree you'd want to come back to next time?"

Gentle prompts

Roots	"Where do you feel most like yourself?" · "Who or what do you come from?"
Trunk	Strengths and qualities, who they are inside. "What's something about you that has stayed the same, even when a lot changed around you?"
Branches	Activities and things they like. "What do you enjoy doing, or want to try?" To move from branch to trunk: "What does [that activity] say about you?"
Leaves	"Which people or places help you feel at ease?"
New growth	"If something new could grow here, what might it be?"
Clouds	"If something's been sitting on your mind lately, where would it go?"

When they say "I don't know"

Offer two options to choose from, or ask for just a color or a single word.

"If you did know, what might it be?"

A "?" on the tree is a complete answer. Silence is okay.

Lowering the spotlight

Sit side by side, facing the page rather than them.

Comment on the process, not the quality: "You came back to the roots."

Song titles, symbols, or doodles can live anywhere on the tree.

Do not interpret the symbols for them. Do not require disclosure or performance.

Ask permission before any body-awareness or music exercise; stop if they're uncomfortable.

Inspired by the Tree of Life approach developed by Ncazelo Ncube and David Denborough (Dulwich Centre). Original worksheet and guide by Woohee (Elise) Kwak.